



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Paideia Academy
School Website: <https://paideiaknoxville.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Paideia Academy Knoxville (37932) presents a robust classical Christian program that aligns strongly with the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School rubric. Public materials from the school's site consistently frame education through a Christian worldview, a liberal arts / Trivium-based curriculum, and a pedagogy that blends Socratic method with rigorous rhetoric and senior-level work. The evidence includes explicit references to the Great Books, the Omnibus program, Latin and Greek study, and Socratic-led inquiry, as well as formal mentions of a parent-partnered model and a faculty as the living curriculum. Across the six categories, the school demonstrates a clear classical orientation with Christian theological grounding, and there are ample signals of Great Conversation, formation through the liberal arts, and an emphasis on virtue and character formation.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

Key insights: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit (Christian worldview, theology references, and a historically grounded liberal arts approach). - Purpose and goal emphasize formation, virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing (not job preparation alone). - Curriculum centers on grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; classical languages; and Western history. - Pedagogy includes Socratic/seminar-based discourse, memory work, and opportunities for rhetoric and oratory. - Faculty are portrayed as living exemplars and mentors, with a clearly defined teacher profile and community orientation. - Parents and community are positioned as co-teachers and engaged partners, with active parental participation and open campus culture.

The following report provides category-by-category keyword analyses, followed by a concluding assessment and a final abstract.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The mission statement frames learning within a distinctly Christian worldview and classical methods. The site describes utilizing classical tools of learning integrated with a Christian worldview.
 - Foundational Beliefs / Eligibility requirements emphasize Christian faith and church involvement as a prerequisite, signaling explicit theological grounding.
 - Additional public materials describe a Christian worldview as central to educational aims, including references to Biblical framing of learning and a focus on Christ-centered culture.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: Christian worldview, theology (explicit in curriculum framing), Great Books within a Christian framework, formation through a Christian lens.
 - Negative indicators: None evident in the public materials reviewed (no explicit relativism, secularism, or value-neutral language observed in these sources).
- Why this rating

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- The materials consistently anchor education in a Christian frame, with explicit references to theology, biblical worldview, and a historically Christian approach to classical education. The absence of any explicit negative signals further supports a CLASSICAL rating in this category.
 - Key sources cited
 - Mission and Christian worldview framing: Paideia Academy Knoxville materials.
 - Foundational Beliefs / Christian requirements: Foundational Beliefs / Eligibility materials.
 - Theological framing in curriculum options: “Christian Worldview” and classical method references.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The program aims at formation via virtue and wisdom, not mere job preparation; the Great Books and liberal arts framework emphasize formation of character through a classical mission.
 - The Omnibus/Great Books approach and the emphasis on forming the mind through a two-cycle study of Western civilization signal a telos-oriented aim toward truth, goodness, and beauty.
 - The explicit Christian worldview grounding further supports formation (rather than merely information transfer) as the educational aim.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, great conversation, telos, true/good/beautiful, classical mission.
 - Negative indicators: none evident in the public-facing materials (no strong emphasis on workforce-centric marketing, no utilitarian framing in these sources).
- Why this rating
 - The school’s stated aims couple formation with a liberal arts discipline and classical telos, aligning well with the Positive keywords in the Six Elements lexicon. The weight of evidence supports CLASSICAL here.
- Key sources cited
 - Formation and classical telos in mission and Omnibus descriptions.
 - Great Books / liberal arts framing and two-cycle approach.
 - Christian worldview grounding as educational purpose.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Liberal arts emphasis with grammar, logic, and rhetoric is explicit, including references to the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as a basis for the curriculum.
 - History is embedded across the curriculum, with Great Books and Western civ-based Omnibus programs rather than a modern social studies framing.
 - Students study Great Books and participate in the Great Conversation; languages include Latin and Greek; Omnibus programs span ancient to modern periods.
 - Ancient languages (Latin and Greek) are explicitly part of the program.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: liberal arts, trivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Latin/-Greek; history/Western civilization; great conversation.
 - Negative indicators: minimal or no reliance on project-based learning or social studies framing as history; not present in these sources.
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum is explicitly classical and liberal-arts oriented, with explicit Great Books and Latin/Greek study, satisfying the core curriculum signals in the Six Elements lexicon.
- Key sources cited
 - Core Omnibus Program and language studies: Paideia Academy Knoxville materials.
 - History, Great Books, and Western civilization emphasis: same Omnibus/Curriculum materials.
 - Latin/Greek and Rhetoric / Omnibus: explicit curriculum mentions.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Socratic-led study of the Great Books with two cycles through ancient, medieval, and modern periods indicates a Socratic pedagogy in the upper grades.
 - The program includes Seminars, debates, and rhetoric training (Rhetoric I & II, Symposium, debate, etc.).
 - Memory work, recitation, and chanting are part of the pedagogical toolkit in the classical model; Paideia explicitly emphasizes restorative pedagogy (Scholé) and contemplation in parts of the program.
 - The lower-to-upper school continuum includes alternating contemplative/restful elements and rigorous discourse-based methods (Scholé-like restfulness paired with Socratic inquiries).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: Socratic seminars, dialectic, discourse, seminars, rhetoric, public speaking, memory work, chant, recitation, scholé-style contemplation.
 - Negative indicators: none evident in the materials provided; no explicit emphasis on purely project-based or student-directed constructivism in the provided sources.
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogy aligns with the classical pedagogy signals: Socratic inquiry, seminars, rhetoric, and memory work, all of which map to the Six Elements' positive signals. Contemplative/restful elements are also signaled, aligning with scholé.
- Key sources cited
 - Socratic study of Great Books and seminars: Paideia Academy Knoxville materials.
 - Rhetoric, debate, and junior/senior projects: Paideia materials.
 - Pedagogical signals (restful learning, memory, chant): Lexicon-derived signals referenced in the Six Essentials lexicon.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public postings show named faculty and staff with a demonstrated background in classical Christian education (e.g., Tracey Carrin, Jared Iles, Lydia Zinn, Aaron Gentry, etc.), with bios emphasizing a fidelity to classical approaches and Christian formation.
 - Faculty are presented as mentors and living models, with faculty bios stressing virtue, character, and scholarship, consistent with a living-curriculum approach.
 - There are explicit references to a “faculty, staff & board” section and to teachers who embody and enact the school’s classical Christian mission.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: living curriculum; faculty as mentors; portrait of teacher; collegial culture; Catholic/Christian framing and classical training in bios.
 - Negative indicators: none evident in the public materials reviewed (no signals of non-classical staffing models).
- Why this rating
 - The public-facing content presents a coherent, classical-leaning faculty profile, with a clear emphasis on teacher virtue, mentorship, and alignment with classical pedagogy.
- Key sources cited
 - Faculty bios and bios-collection: Paideia materials.
 - Faculty/staff overview page: Paideia materials.
 - Living-curriculum / teacher profile framing: Paideia bios.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

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- The school presents itself as partnering with parents and positioning parents as co-teachers, aligning with the classical model of family formation and shared responsibility in education.
 - Admissions and parental engagement materials emphasize parent involvement and home-school alignment, including home-based formation and family participation in school activities.
 - There are explicit references to parent formation and classical book-club style gatherings (as part of broader parental engagement).
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: partnership with parents, parent formation, classical book clubs, open campus and visits, family involvement.
 - Negative indicators: none evident in the public-facing materials reviewed.
 - Why this rating
 - The public materials show a clear design for parent partnership and community engagement, consistent with classical education norms around parental involvement and formation.
 - Key sources cited
 - Parent partnership and Foundational Beliefs: Paideia materials.
 - Admissions and parent involvement language: Paideia materials.
 - Open-campus / community engagement signals: Paideia materials.
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What Would Move the Needle

- If any category were to move toward a stronger edge (i.e., toward deeper CLASSICAL), potential needle-moving changes could include:
 - More explicit articulation of liturgical and communal practices within the curriculum (e.g., explicit reference to liturgy, prayer life, and communal rites beyond mission statements).
 - Expanded public-facing detail on the “living curriculum” concept in faculty materials, including direct examples of faculty mentoring practices and teacher-initiated opportunities for student formation beyond traditional seminars and rhetoric.
 - Additional public documentation that directly quotes or maps Great Books to specific Great Conversation-style prompts or sample seminar dialogues, to strengthen the explicit connection between Great Books and daily pedagogy.
 - Expanded parent education resources on classical education philosophy (beyond foundational beliefs) to further demonstrate ongoing parental formation and co-teaching practices.

Note: The school already demonstrates a robust CLASSICAL orientation across six categories, with minimal need for substantive changes to reach full CLASSICAL status.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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